

CASTE SYSTEM: STRUCTURE AND CONTEMPORARY DYNAMICS

LEVEL OF ANALYSIS → FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR → MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE → MOBILITY STRATEGIES → DOMINANT CASTE TEST → CASTE AND CLASS

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g1 • explicit approval of this exact generation is required • all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 LEVEL OF ANALYSIS

LEVEL OF ANALYSIS FOUR-FOLD TEXTUAL IDEAL TYPE, NORMATIVE LOCAL ENDOGAMOUS BIRTH GROUP, OBSERVABLE NARROWER ENDOGAMY CIRCLE INSIDE A JATI ANSWER AT THE JATI LEVEL, ARGUE WITH THE VARNA

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative	SUB-JATI → narrower endogamy circle inside a jati	VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative
JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable	RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template	JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable
SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION - VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative - JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable	DECISIVE DISTINCTION - SUB-JATI → narrower endogamy circle inside a jati - RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT - VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative - JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template.

01

STAGE 01 FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR RATE OF CHANGE

FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR RATE OF CHANGE MOST CONSISTENTLY OBSERVED, CHANGES LEAST LOCALLY RANKED BY PURITY AND POLLUTION HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP FIXED BY BIRTH OCCUPATION LINK WEAKEST JOINT, BROKEN BY URBAN WORK

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
ENDOAMY → most consistently observed, changes least	HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP → fixed by birth	ENDOAMY → most consistently observed, changes least
HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution	OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work	HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution
SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION - ENDOAMY → most consistently observed, changes least - HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution	DECISIVE DISTINCTION - HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP → fixed by birth - OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT - ENDOAMY → most consistently observed, changes least - HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work.

02

STAGE 02 MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE TOGETHER

MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE TOGETHER CASTE ENDOGAMY MARRY WITHIN THE JATI GOTRA EXOGAMY MARRY OUTSIDE THE CLAN LINEAGE A BOUNDED BUT NON-CONSANGUINEOUS MARRIAGE CIRCLE CASTE IS REPRODUCED GENERATION BY GENERATION

CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati → GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage → RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle → CONSEQUENCE → caste is reproduced generation by generation			
SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT • CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati • GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage		MECHANISM OF CHANGE • RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle • CONSEQUENCE → caste is reproduced generation by generation	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT • CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati • GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle.

03

STAGE 03 MOBILITY STRATEGIES

MOBILITY STRATEGIES EMULATE A LOCALLY HIGHER-STATUS CASTE CLAIMS RANK INSIDE THE EXISTING HIERARCHY NEW VALUES FROM WESTERN CONTACT CAN SUBVERT THE HIERARCHY RATHER THAN CONFIRM IT

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste	WESTERNISATION → new values from Western contact	SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy	EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it	EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy
SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

03

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT

- CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati
- GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

MECHANISM OF CHANGE

- RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle
- CONSEQUENCE → caste is reproduced generation by generation

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati
- GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle.

03

STAGE 03

MOBILITY STRATEGIES

MOBILITY STRATEGIES

EMULATE A LOCALLY HIGHER-STATUS CASTE

CLAIMS RANK INSIDE THE EXISTING HIERARCHY

NEW VALUES FROM WESTERN CONTACT

CAN SUBVERT THE HIERARCHY RATHER THAN CONFIRM IT

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste	WESTERNISATION → new values from Western contact	SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy	EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it	EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION

- SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
- EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- WESTERNISATION → new values from Western contact
- EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

- SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
- EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it.

04

STAGE 04

DOMINANT CASTE TEST

DOMINANT CASTE TEST

IS THE CASTE LOCALLY NUMEROUS

DOES IT HOLD A SIGNIFICANT SHARE OF LOCAL LAND

DOES IT CONTROL POLITICAL AND PANCHAYAT POSITIONS

DOMINANCE CAN SIT BELOW THE RITUAL TOP

NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous

LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land

OFFICE → does it control political and Panchayat positions

VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT	MECHANISM OF CHANGE	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
• NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous • LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land	• OFFICE → does it control political and Panchayat positions • VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top	• NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous • LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top.

05

STAGE 05

CASTE AND CLASS

CASTE AND CLASS

CASTE RANK AND ECONOMIC CLASS COINCIDE LOCALLY

RICH AND POOR HOUSEHOLDS INSIDE ONE CASTE

URBAN EMPLOYMENT AND MARKET CREDENTIALS

THE OVERLAP IS LOOSENING, NOT ABOLISHED

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally	DRIVER → urban employment and market credentials	OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste	LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished	CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION

- OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
- CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- DRIVER → urban employment and market credentials
- LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

- OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
- CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished.

06

STAGE 06

ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION

ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION

OCCUPATIONAL ALLOCATION AND PUBLIC PURITY ENFORCEMENT

REPLACED BY

CASTE ASSOCIATIONS, TRUSTS AND ELECTORAL BLOCS

ENDOGAMY AND INTIMATE-SPHERE DISCRIMINATION

CHANGE OF REGISTER, NOT DISAPPEARANCE

WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement

REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination

VERDICT → change of register, not disappearance

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT	MECHANISM OF CHANGE	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
• WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement	• UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination	• WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement

CASTE SYSTEM: STRUCTURE AND CONTEMPORARY DYNAMICS • TILE 2/4 • same master rows 2363-5597 of 10324 • continues below

06

STAGE 06

ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION

ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION

OCCUPATIONAL ALLOCATION AND PUBLIC PURITY ENFORCEMENT

REPLACED BY

CASTE ASSOCIATIONS, TRUSTS AND ELECTORAL BLOCS

ENDOGENY AND INTIMATE-SPHERE DISCRIMINATION

CHANGE OF REGISTER, NOT DISAPPEARANCE

WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement

→

REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

→

UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination

→

VERDICT → change of register, not disappearance

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT

WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement

REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

MECHANISM OF CHANGE

UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination

VERDICT → change of register, not disappearance

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement

REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs.

07

STAGE 07

FLUID AND STATIC RESOLVED BY LEVEL

FLUID AND STATIC RESOLVED BY LEVEL

STATIC LAYER

ENDOGENY, HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP, SEGREGATION

FLUID LAYER

RANK CLAIMS, DOMINANCE, MARKET MOBILITY

RANK IS LOCALLY CONSTRUCTED, BOUNDARY IS MARITAL

THE PARADOX IS A LEVEL DISTINCTION, NOT A CONTRADICTION

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT

STATIC LAYER → endogamy, hereditary membership, segregation

FLUID LAYER → rank claims, dominance, market mobility

MECHANISM OF CHANGE

WHY → rank is locally constructed, boundary is marital

ANSWER → the paradox is a level distinction, not a contradiction

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

STATIC LAYER → endogamy, hereditary membership, segregation

FLUID LAYER → rank claims, dominance, market mobility

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: ANSWER → the paradox is a level distinction, not a contradiction.

08

STAGE 08

IDENTITY AXES BY ARENA

IDENTITY AXES BY ARENA

JATI AND SUB-JATI DECIDE THE BOUNDARY

SHRINE AND DEVOTION

SECT THROUGH DOCTRINE AND LINEAGE

ELECTORAL MOBILISATION

JATI CLUSTERS AND RELIGION

DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE

REGION AND LANGUAGE

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary	ELECTORAL MOBILISATION → jati clusters and religion	MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary
SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage	DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE → region and language	SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION

MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary

SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

ELECTORAL MOBILISATION → jati clusters and religion

DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE → region and language

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary

SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage.

09

STAGE 09

TWO MARRIAGE BOUNDARIES

TWO MARRIAGE BOUNDARIES

PARITY PROTECTS STATUS AND RESOURCE BASE

BELONGING, KINSHIP AND COMMUNITY SANCTION

CIVIL ROUTE

SPECIAL MARRIAGE ACT, 1954 EXISTS ACROSS RELIGIONS

DIFFERENT GUARDS, THEREFORE DIFFERENT SPEEDS

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base	CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions	INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base
INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction	VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds	INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION

INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base

INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions

VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base

INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions.

CASTE SYSTEM: STRUCTURE AND CONTEMPORARY DYNAMICS • TILE 3/4 • same master rows 4727-7961 of 10324 • continues below

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage.

09

STAGE 09 TWO MARRIAGE BOUNDARIES

TWO MARRIAGE BOUNDARIES

PARITY PROTECTS STATUS AND RESOURCE BASE

BELONGING, KINSHIP AND COMMUNITY SANCTION

CIVIL ROUTE

SPECIAL MARRIAGE ACT, 1954 EXISTS ACROSS RELIGIONS

DIFFERENT GUARDS, THEREFORE DIFFERENT SPEEDS

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION

INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base

INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions

VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base

INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION

• INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base

• INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

• CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions

• VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

• INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base

• INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions.

10

STAGE 10 MEASUREMENT STATUS

MEASUREMENT STATUS

PIB 30 APRIL 2025

CASTE ENUMERATION ANNOUNCED FOR CENSUS 2027

GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E)

FIXES THE REFERENCE DATES

PROSPECTIVE, SO NO CASTE COUNT MAY BE QUOTED

NOT INDIA'S FIRST HISTORICAL CASTE ENUMERATION

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION

PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027

GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

STATUS → prospective, so no caste count may be quoted

LIMIT → not India's first historical caste enumeration

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027

GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION

• PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027

• GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

• STATUS → prospective, so no caste count may be quoted

• LIMIT → not India's first historical caste enumeration

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT

• PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027

• GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT → not India's first historical caste enumeration.

11

STAGE 11 CASTE ANSWER SPINE

CASTE ANSWER SPINE

NAME THE LEVEL AND THE DEMAND FAMILY

STRUCTURE, MOBILITY, DOMINANCE, ASSOCIATION

WHAT CHANGED AGAINST WHAT DID NOT

ARENA-SPECIFIC VERDICT WITH THE MEASUREMENT CAVEAT

OPEN → name the level and the demand family

BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association

TENSION → what changed against what did not

CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT

• OPEN → name the level and the demand family

• BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association

MECHANISM OF CHANGE

• TENSION → what changed against what did not

• CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• OPEN → name the level and the demand family

• BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

CASTE ASSOCIATIONS AS POLITICAL INTERMEDIARIES

JATI-LEVEL BODIES INCREASINGLY

CASTE-CENSUS DEBATE (SOCIOLOGICAL, NOT ENUMERATION-METHODOLOGY)

DEMANDS FOR

RESERVATION AS A STRUCTURAL RESPONSE (CROSS-LINKED, NOT RESTATED)

URBAN CASTE PERSISTENCE

EVEN WHERE RITUAL PRACTICES WEAKEN, CASTE-BASED NETWORKS

OPTIONAL THEORETICAL DEPTH

• CAUTION: Caste associations as political intermediaries: jati-level bodies increasingly

• CAUTION: Caste-census debate (sociological, not enumeration-methodology): demands for

• Reservation as a structural response (cross-linked, not restated): constitutional

• CAUTION: Urban caste persistence: even where ritual practices weaken, caste-based networks

DATA / CLAIM LIMIT

• CAUTION: Boundary case 1: a Sanskritising jati that gains ritual respectability but remains

• CAUTION: Boundary case 2: a numerically dominant but ritually middling caste controlling a

• CAUTION: Boundary case 3: an intercaste marriage between two economically equal

• CAUTION: Sanskritisation's ceiling: emulation can raise local ritual standing but cannot by

COMPARATIVE SOCIAL NUANCE

• CAUTION: Marriage-trend generalisation risk: the 2024 PYQ's trend (rising intercaste,

• M.N. Srinivas developed both Sanskritisation and dominant caste from his Rampura

• Dominant caste is defined by numbers + land + political power, independent of ritual

• Sanskritisation operates within the existing hierarchy; Westernisation introduces

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.